

IN PROFILE

Savva Mamontov

Pre-Revolutionary Russia, although backward by the standards of Western Europe, was changing fast toward the end of the 19th century. The economy grew in harness with the expansion of the railroads, as did the cultural life of the major cities. The railroad tycoon Savva Mamontov (1841–1918) made a fortune and spent much of it on his Moscow Private Opera company. Mamontov's money bankrolled a long run of Rimsky-Korsakov operas, beginning in 1897 with *Sadko* and expanding (even after Mamontov was unjustly imprisoned for embezzlement two years later) to include such works as *The Czar's Bride*, in 1899, and *Kashchey the Immortal*, in 1902.



PORTRAIT OF SAVVA IVANOVICH MAMONTOV, 1879

Nikolai Rimsky-Korsakov belonged to the generation of Russia's "secular priesthood," as the philosopher Isaiah Berlin described